

players look for either ready-made garments or fabric, they look for a vertically integrated player. We have one of the world's best factories in terms of ability to give worsted fabrics, plus we have four units in Bengaluru and one in Ethiopia, where we do ready-made B2B garmenting. So, we are able to give end-to-end vertically integrated, very strong world class facilities, people," he says.

Two, certain consumer trends in India are also being targeted by Kataria. Casualization and hybrid formals is one such, where people go to work wearing attire that is not strictly formal, yet not totally casual either. Think start-ups, the tech crowd and millennials, and their approach to dressing. You'll get the drift. "Two of my brands, Park Avenue and Raymond Ready to Wear, are formal brands. We are going to stretch these two brands into casual as well. The casualization play between my apparel brands is going to become very strong. And that's an area where we are focussing on both product and design," says Kataria. He's also betting big on this trend spilling into fabrics. "We are seeing that even within fabrics, it is no longer the blacks and the blues and greys that people prefer. They are open to buying prints, colourful linens, more casual designs." Plus, there's a lot of work going on in innovations such as a techno-stretch fabric—which as the name suggests are fabrics with some stretch built in—and even a stain-repellent fabric.

But what gets Kataria most excited is ethnic apparel, through its brand Ethnix by Raymond. If you think ethnic is only for weddings and festivals, you have another think coming. Kataria caught this correspondent by surprise by pointing out that the interview was being conducted by someone wearing a bundi, which is what he calls



"Completing projects in time gives comfort to consumers... anybody coming in will have to deliver on time and deliver the quality promised"

ANSHUMAN MAGAZINE

CHAIRMAN & CEO, INDIA, SOUTH EAST ASIA, MIDDLE EAST AND AFRICA, CBRE



"Earlier, there was mistrust in the [real estate] market... that gap was identified by a number of corporate players. Their entry got back the confidence of buyers"

KARAN SINGH SODI

SENIOR MD, MUMBAI METROPOLITAN REGION & GUJARAT, JLL INDIA

"smart ethnic". The bundi, kurta and other ethnic wear are becoming fairly common in the workplace, and remain popular in weddings and festivals. Raymond is targeting a mix of exclusive Ethnix stores as well as shop-in-shop placements in TRS outlets for its ethnics drive. Antique Stock Broking's Kundu points out that while there is competition, there are also a lot of unorganised players in this segment, which

would help the overall ethnic portfolio in terms of consumers wanting to buy branded ethnics. "Raymond is under-indexed in ethnics and even branded casuals, so they will start from a lower base and they can scale up profitably," he says.

Raymond also has a ₹1,000-crore-plus business of denim, which it runs through a 50:50 joint venture with UCO of Belgium. The entity, called Raymond UCO Denim, has been around for 25 years now, and has become one of Raymond's biggest businesses under CEO Arvind Mathur, 62, a veteran of 29 years at British industrial thread manufacturer Coats PLC, before joining Raymond. Despite cotton prices doubling in recent years, both denim fabric and ready-made apparel have done well on the strength of its B2B relationships. "A bulk of our business has been on the export side and we have grown significantly there. And even in the Indian market, all the premium labels would be using our fabric in their jeans," says Mathur. Apart from supplying to other brands, Raymond UCO Denim now also supplies denim fabric and readymade jeans to Raymond brands such as Parx. Going forward, Mathur is focussed on expanding his garmenting footprint, which is where demand is climbing.

The final piece is engineering and auto components. If you're surprised that Raymond is in this business, well, don't be. Even Balasubramanian V., 63, the MD of JK Files & Engineering, a 25-year veteran of Brakes India and Bosch till he joined Raymond in October 2017, didn't know about it before he got the job offer from Raymond. The division's sales fell just 7.4 per cent in FY21, the lowest of all Raymond's businesses, but recovered smartly thereafter. This growth has come on the back of a good showing from its two com-